

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



INDIA-MYANMAR - 1

MODULE - 30

IMPORTANT NEIGHBOUR OF INDIA

- 1 India-Myanmar relations are rooted in shared historical, ethnic, cultural and religious ties.
- 2 India is the birthplace of Buddhism and is a pilgrimage centre for the people of Myanmar.
- 3 It shares a land border with Indian states of Mizoram, Nagaland, Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh.
- 4 A large population of Indian origin lives in Myanmar.
- 5 Buddhism, Business, Bollywood, Bharatanatyam and Burma teak— are the five B's that define India-Myanmar relations.

- 6 Over the years, the geographical proximity has contributed to the development of cordial relations and facilitated people-to people contact between the two nations



1 Buddhism has been a historical connect between India and Myanmar. During the colonial times, this connect brought the two countries closer.

2 However, formal diplomatic relations between India and Myanmar were established only after independence in 1948.

3 In the initial years after independence, the relations were strong because of cultural links and growing commercial interactions.

4 India helped Myanmar address its internal security issues.



TREATY OF FRIENDSHIP 1951

Under the 1951 treaty, India and Myanmar agreed

- To establish everlasting peace and friendship and promote cordial relations
- Disputes to be resolved diplomatically through peaceful means
- Strengthen diplomatic and consular relations



CLOSENESS TO CHINA

- 1 India became the largest importer of Burmese rice.
- 2 These ties were, however, short lived. With the overthrow of democracy by a military coup in 1962, India did not favour the new government in power.
- 3 This led to Myanmar getting closer to China. This situation deteriorated further when the military led junta government started suppressing the pro-democracy movements in the country.

- 4 This led to a huge refugee crisis in India as these protestors sought to take refuge in India.



RENEWAL OF TIES

- 5 Ultimately, in 1987 Prime Minister Gandhi laid the foundations of a strong relationship between India and Myanmar.
- 6 The ties witnessed a turnaround during the 1990s with India's adoption of the Look East policy.
- 7 The democratic government in Myanmar under the leadership of Ms. Suu Kyi led India and Myanmar share amicable relations



AREAS OF COOPERATION

The areas of cooperation between India and Myanmar are:

1. Political
2. Strategic
3. Defence
4. Economic
5. Development aid



POLITICAL

- Myanmar looks at India for establishment and smooth running of democratic institutions and practices.

1 In 2017, a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed between the Election Commission of India and Union Election of Myanmar.

2 In 2017, an MoU was signed on cooperation between Myanmar Press Council and the Press Council of India.



STRATEGIC

- 1 Myanmar acts as a Gateway to East for India
- 2 Myanmar is the only ASEAN member that shares its borders with India and thus provides opportunity for deepening ties with south-east Asian nations under the Look East and Act East policies.
- 3 In addition to a land border, both countries also share a long maritime boundary in the strategically significant Andaman Sea and Bay of Bengal where they face common challenges of arising China, illegal fishing and smuggling.



STRATEGIC

- Myanmar is important for the Security of Northeast of India.

1 It offers us an alternative access route to the northeast.

2 Economic development of north-east and connectivity can accelerate with Myanmar's cooperation

3 Large number of cross-border ethnic groups and insurgents from northeast India have military bases in Myanmar.

4 The porous borders provide fertile grounds for organized crime, i.e., human trafficking, drugs peddling and smuggling of arms and ammunition.



STRATEGIC

- 5 These can be checked only with the collaborative effort between India and Myanmar
- 6 The two countries have signed an agreement to share real time intelligence to combat Indian insurgents operating out of the border region.
- 7 The pact envisages the conduct of coordinated patrols on each side of the border and maritime boundary and entails exchange of information to jointly combat insurgency, arms smuggling and drug, human and wildlife trafficking.



DEFENCE AND SECURITY COOPERATION

- 1** The signing of MoU on Border Cooperation, training the army, air force and naval staff talks are indicators of strong defence and border cooperation between India and Myanmar.
- 2** Myanmar side has provided assurances at the highest levels that it will cooperate with India in taking necessary action in preventing the use of Myanmar territory for anti-India activity.
- 3** In July 2017, Sr Gen Hlaing, of Myanmar defence services visited India to further cement defence ties.
- 4** India aids Myanmar for military modernization. Myanmar has acquired rocket launchers, night vision systems, radar and engineering equipment from India.



DEFENCE AND SECURITY COOPERATION

5 The two neighbours also conducted joint army exercises called **IMBAX in 2017** and have been conducting joint maritime patrols since 2013.

6 On maritime security, both countries have agreed on **Maritime Security Cooperation in the Bay of Bengal** and by extending cooperation in the Indian Ocean region, both countries have the potential to **develop an alternate inter-portal trade route via Bay of Bengal.**

7 To strengthen its **Made In India arms industry**, India has identified Myanmar as key to **increasing its military exports.**



ECONOMIC COOPERATION

- 1 President Kovind visited Myanmar in December 2018 and reiterated the importance of Myanmar for India's especially Northeast's economy
- 2 During the visit, India handed over 50 housing units to Myanmar and the countries signed two MoUs in the area of judicial training and Science and Technology.
- 3 The United Bank of India signed banking agreements with Myanmar Foreign Trade Bank (MFTB), Myanmar Investment and Commercial Bank (MICB), Myanmar Economic Bank (MEB) and nine other banks of Myanmar to facilitate bilateral trade.
- 4 Myanmar has the potential to address India's energy requirements. Most Indian investments in Myanmar have been in the oil and gas sector.
- 5 India assisted Myanmar in the setting up of a heavy turbo-truck assembly plant of TATA Motors in Myanmar.



ECONOMIC COOPERATION

1. TRADE

- India is Myanmar's fifth largest trading partner.
- Indian exports to Myanmar include sugar and pharmaceuticals. Myanmar exports to India is dominated by agriculture products like beans, pulses and timber; teak and hardwood.
- Moreh and Zokhawthar are important points of border trade between the two countries.

2. TRANSIT

Two land border crossing between the countries have been opened with a hope to accelerate tourism between Northeast India and Myanmar.

1. Tamu/Moreh in Manipur
2. Rihkhawadar-Zowkhawtar in Mizoram

- India's long-term strategic goal is to create a Special Economic Zone surrounding the Sittwe port to build India's footprint in Rakhine and boost its presence in the Bay of Bengal.
- The objective is to counter Chinese Kyaukpu port which is expected to increase China's geostrategic footprint in Rakhine.



DEVELOPMENT AID

- 1 India understands the importance of supporting Myanmar's education system.
- 2 It is expected to strengthen India's soft power in the region.
- 3 To further this, India has committed to extend \$1.7 billion of aids and loans to Myanmar for infrastructure development to provide schools and health care centres in Myanmar.



DISASTER RELIEF

- 1 India supported Myanmar with relief materials and assistance after the cataclysmic cyclone 'Nargis' which hit the country in May 2008.
- 2 India also provided assistance of US \$1 million for humanitarian relief and rehabilitation in the areas affected by the severe earthquake in Shan State in March 2011.
- 3 India assisted Myanmar in humanitarian relief operations following natural calamities like Cyclone Mora (2017), Komen (2015), etc. apart from monetary support in rehabilitation and reconstruction.



CULTURAL COOPERATION

In order to strengthen the strong historical Buddhist ties with Myanmar, India is undertaking key initiatives-

- 1 India donated a 16-ft replica of the Sarnath Buddha Statue which has been installed in the premises of Shwedagon pagoda in Yangon.
- 2 India supported Myanmar in the restoration of Ananda Temple in Bagan.
- 3 ICCR, India and Sitagu International Buddhist Academy organized an International Conference on Buddhist Cultural Heritage.

- 4 India has built on the cultural affinities shared with Myanmar by assisting in restoration work at Anand temple in Bagan. This gives India an enormous goodwill.
- 5 Both the sides signed an agreement for cultural exchange program for the years 2017 to 2020.



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

BIMSTEC

- 1 The Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC) is an international organisation involving a group of seven countries in South Asia and South East Asia.
- 2 The participating countries are Bangladesh, India, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Bhutan and Nepal.
- 3 Myanmar is a key component of India's ambitions at bridging South Asia and South-East Asia through BIMSTEC which brings together 21% of world's population and has a combined GDP of nearly \$2.5 trillion.



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

MEKONG GANGA COOPERATION

- 1 Myanmar is a member of the Mekong Ganga Cooperation (MGC) since its inception in November 2000.
- 2 It promotes cooperation in tourism, culture, education, as well as transport and communications.
- 3 Both the Ganga and the Mekong are civilizational rivers, and the MGC initiative aims to facilitate closer contacts among the people inhabiting these two major river basins.



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

BANGLADESH-CHINA-INDIA-MYANMAR FORUM FOR REGIONAL COOPERATION (BCIM)

- 1 It is a sub-regional organisation of Asian nations aimed at greater integration of trade and investment between the four countries.
- 2 China and India are trying to establish the Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar (BCIM) economic corridor, which is expected to link Kolkata with Kunming, the capital of China's Yunnan province, passing through Myanmar and Bangladesh, with Mandalay and Dhaka among the focal points.

- 3 The focus on linking provinces and States in this case, Yunnan and West Bengal



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

INDIA-MYANMAR-THAILAND FRIENDSHIP HIGHWAY

- 1 India and Myanmar have agreed to a 4-lane, 3200 km triangular highway connecting India, Myanmar and Thailand. The trilateral highway, Asian Highway project will be a game changer for India, notably for its Northeast states.
- 2 The highway is expected to connect Moreh in India to Mae Sot in Thailand via Myanmar.
- 3 Myanmar has asked India for the highway to be built connecting Mandalay as it is an important commercial city in Myanmar.



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

INDIA-MYANMAR-THAILAND FRIENDSHIP HIGHWAY

The importance of the project

- It would connect the Mekong sub-region with India.
- It would enhance connectivity between ASEAN and India.
- From an economic viewpoint, it would benefit the North-east states in India.
- It would enhance trade opportunities and provide greater access.

- India has also decided to upgrade the Kalewa-Yargi road segment to highway standard, while Myanmar would develop the Yargi-Monywa portion, and this would help to connect Moreh in India to Mae Sot in Thailand via Myanmar.
- This in turn would improve India's connectivity and relationship with both Myanmar and Thailand.

But the pace of development needs to be increased to build the necessary infrastructure.



MAP OF PROPOSED INDIA-MYANMAR-THAILAND HIGHWAY



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

KALADAN MULTI-MODAL TRANSIT TRANSPORT PROJECT

- 1** The Kaladan Multi-modal Transit Transport Project will connect the eastern Indian seaport of Kolkata with Sittwe seaport in Myanmar
- 2** It will then link Sittwe seaport to Lashio in Myanmar via Kaladan river boat route and then from Lashio on to Mizoram in India by road transport.
- 3** It will reduce distance from Kolkata to Mizoram by approximately 1000 km and cut travelling time to 3-4 days for transport of goods.



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

KALADAN MULTI-MODAL TRANSIT TRANSPORT PROJECT

4 It is necessary in case of any conflict with China as present route, i.e., chicken neck could be blocked by China in conflict situation.

5 The access to the sea that the project provides its North-Eastern states could boost their economies.

6 It would strengthen India's trade and transport links with Southeast Asia.

7 It will be instrumental for "Act East Policy".



MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

CLMV – CAMBODIA MYANMAR LAOS AND VIETNAM

- 1 There is a proposal to set up manufacturing hubs in CLMV countries.
- 2 These countries have the highest foreign direct investment growth in the region, especially in manufacturing.
- 3 As India seeks to deepen economic partnerships with Southeast Asia under an “Act East” policy, it has prioritized CLMV economies with budgetary allocation of Rs.100 crores (US\$16.1 million) to oversee investment in the CLMV manufacturing hubs.



AREAS OF COOPERATION

MULTILATERAL COOPERATION

CLMV – CAMBODIA MYANMAR LAOS AND VIETNAM

- 4 There is a history of industrial cooperation between India and the CLMV countries.
- 5 Major Indian investment in Vietnam includes large projects such as oil exploration, power generation, and chemical manufacturing.
- 6 In January 2015, there were a total of 84 projects funded by Indian investments in Vietnam.
- 7 Two highways involving Myanmar play a vital role in improving connectivity in the South East Asian region:



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